UNCTC Background Guide - *SOMUN 2026*

UNCTC

Agenda: *Countering the Use of Artificial Intelligence and Emerging Technologies by Terrorist Organizations in Digital and Modern Warfare*

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Letter from the Chairperson

Dear Delegates,

Welcome to the 8th edition of SOMUN. It is my pleasure to welcome you to the **Counter-Terrorism Committee** (CTC). As we prepare to deliberate on the agenda, *"Countering the Use of Artificial Intelligence and Emerging Technologies by Terrorist Organizations in Digital and Modern Warfare,"* I encourage each of you to approach this committee with curiosity, critical thinking, and a willingness to engage with perspectives that may differ from your own.

It is no surprise that technology today has transformed the way the world communicates, operates, and protects itself. However, not only has it mutated in different forms and variants, its use has become unregulated and often unethical. Today, the same advancements are exploited by terrorist organizations to spread propaganda, facilitate recruitment, manipulate information, and develop new methods of carrying out attacks. In every illegal operation sanctioned ever, technology has played a vital part. Take for example the infamous **9/11** attacks– even though the hijackers used simple physical tools to take control, the planes, regarded as one of humanity's best technological advancement, played the most significant part in carrying out the attacks. The chain of events following the attack meant mass surveillance, radar tracking, an increased budget for counter-terrorism measures, you name it. Therefore, it is safe to say that the challenge before us is not simply to identify these threats, but to consider how the international community can respond effectively without compromising human rights, national sovereignty, or the responsible use of technology.

As delegates, you are expected to go beyond prepared speeches and familiar policy statements– question existing approaches, examine the limitations of international cooperation, and propose solutions that are both practical and adaptable to an evolving technological landscape. I would highly encourage each of you to not only do an extensive research on your country's stance, history with CTC, real-life case studies, and foreign policy, but also dig in and find out information about several prominent **non-state actors**, whose reputation often precedes themselves. Note that effective diplomacy needs more than just defending your nation's stance; it also involves understanding the worries of others and, when feasible, identifying points of agreement. On that note, the committee represents 16 non-state actors, armed movements, and state-linked organizations with distinct political objectives, ideological foundations, territorial interests, organizational structures, and technological capabilities. These include groups operating across the Middle East, South Asia, and Africa, ranging from established political-military movements to insurgent organizations and armed factions. Their relationships with governments, levels of external support, and legal classifications vary significantly; not all are designated terrorist organizations under every national or international framework.

With that being said, I look forward to witnessing the discussions, negotiations, and ideas that emerge from this committee. Do not hesitate to ask questions, collaborate with other delegates, and most importantly, ***try***. Your country (for example) could have a terrible reputation when it comes to the agenda, or the opposite. Regardless, the path for debate lies in how you decide to approach the agenda, and what is best for your country.

Wishing you all a productive and engaging committee session. ***Let there be chaos!***

Sincerely,
Anirud S

Chairperson
Counter-Terrorism Committee (CTC)

About UNCTC

The United Nations Security Council Counter-Terrorism Committee (**CTC**), commonly referred to in some Model United Nations settings as the UNCTC, was established on 28 September 2001 under Security Council Resolution 1373 following *the terrorist attacks of 11 September 2001*. Comprising all 15 members of the UN Security Council, the Committee monitors Member States' implementation of

international counter-terrorism obligations, including measures to prevent terrorist financing, deny safe havens, strengthen domestic legislation, and improve international cooperation. The Committee is supported by the Counter-Terrorism Committee Executive Directorate (CTED), which conducts assessments, identifies gaps in national counter-terrorism capabilities, and facilitates access to technical assistance.

The CTC's work has evolved alongside the changing nature of terrorism, including the exploitation of information and communications technologies, artificial intelligence, unmanned aircraft systems, and digital financial networks. Through Security Council resolutions, policy guidance, and international cooperation, the Committee encourages Member States to strengthen their capacity to prevent and respond to emerging terrorist threats. Its approach also recognizes the importance of complying with international law, including applicable human rights obligations, when implementing counter-terrorism measures.

In this simulation, however, the committee adopts an adapted format in which delegates represent a range of non-state actors, armed movements, and state-linked organizations rather than the 15 Member States that constitute the real-world CTC. These actors have different political objectives, organizational structures, capabilities, and relationships with governments; they also differ in their legal status and designation across jurisdictions. Their inclusion is a feature of the simulation and does not imply that they are members of the actual UN committee or that they share the same legal classification. Delegates are expected to understand their assigned actors' interests, assess the implications of emerging technologies, and negotiate realistic responses through directives while considering international law, civilian protection, and the wider consequences of their decisions.

Introduction to the Agenda

The swift expansion of artificial intelligence (AI) and other cutting-edge technology has completely changed how information is produced, shared, and utilized in contemporary warfare. These technologies provide new weaknesses that terrorist groups and armed non-state actors may try to exploit, even as they provide substantial advantages for security, communication, and intelligence analysis. The difficulties of counterterrorism and contemporary warfare have taken on new dimensions because of technologies like **generative AI, deepfakes, automated information systems,**

unmanned aircraft systems (UAS), cyber capabilities, and digital financial networks.

Beyond cyberspace, the misuse of these technologies may have repercussions. For example, Cyberattacks on vital infrastructure, coordinated disinformation, online recruitment, artificially created propaganda, and the abuse of digital platforms can erode public confidence, widen societal divides, and make security responses more difficult. However, organizations differ greatly in their technological capabilities, and using a certain technology does not always increase an actor's power or the effectiveness of their activities. How these techniques are used depends on a number of factors, including access to money, technological know-how, outside assistance, and the political and military climate.

In order to overcome these obstacles, security issues must be balanced with international law, humanitarian concerns, and civilian protection. Difficult issues pertaining to accountability, attribution, information sharing, digital surveillance, and the regulation of developing technologies confront states, international organizations, tech firms, and other pertinent parties. Effective countermeasures must take into account the dangers of technology abuse as well as the potential for privacy, freedom of expression, and other fundamental rights to be violated by ill-thought-out counterterrorism measures. It is also important to note that Delegates will investigate how developing technologies in digital and modern warfare may be used, acquired, countered, or impacted by the actors they represent in this modified CTC simulation. Delegates should assess their assigned actor's strategic interests, alliances, limitations, and connections with state authorities rather than presuming that all actors have the same skills or goals. The committee will investigate workable ways to manage the wider political and security ramifications of these advancements, limit harm to people, and address technological dangers through discussion and the creation of directives.

Mandate and Role of the Counter-Terrorism Committee

The United Nations Security Council Counter-Terrorism Committee (CTC) was established under Security Council Resolution 1373 (2001) to monitor how Member States implement international counter-terrorism obligations. Promoting measures to stop terrorist financing, limiting safe havens and support for terrorist organizations, bolstering domestic counterterrorism laws, enhancing information sharing, and facilitating international cooperation in the investigation and prosecution of terrorism-related offenses are all part of its mandate. Through later Security Council resolutions,

such as those pertaining to foreign terrorist fighters and incitement to terrorism, the Committee also handles pertinent issues.

The CTC does not directly conduct military operations, arrest suspects, or independently enforce counter-terrorism laws within countries. Rather, it keeps an eye on implementation, finds areas where Member States' efforts are lacking, encourages the sharing of best practices, and makes technical support more accessible. This work is supported by the **Counter-Terrorism Committee Executive Directorate (CTED)**, which was created by Resolution 1535 (2004), through expert evaluations, country visits, and threat analysis. The UN Charter and relevant international legislation, including human rights commitments, must be understood in relation to all CTC activities.

For this committee, the mandate has been adapted to examine the use of artificial intelligence and emerging technologies by the assigned non-state actors, armed movements, and state-linked organizations. Delegates will negotiate directives addressing the technological, operational, legal, and humanitarian dimensions of the agenda.

The Evolving Technological Landscape of Terrorism

There lies a stark difference in technology 30 years ago versus the modern day. Today, you can fit almost terabytes worth of data in just your phone, or have a robot deliver your food to you, or even enter the world of Virtual Reality to just name a few. Over the past 30 years, there has been a significant change in the link between technology and terrorism. Social media and the internet have been used by terrorist groups to generate money, recruit members, spread propaganda, and communicate internationally. Malicious actors now have access to a wider variety of technologies thanks to advancements in artificial intelligence (AI), unmanned aerial systems

(UAS), encrypted communication platforms, virtual assets, and cybercrime-related services. The United Nations Counter-Terrorism Center (UNCCT) and the United Nations Interregional Crime and Justice study Institute (UNICRI) claim that these developments pose new hazards that call for international collaboration, study, and proactive preventative measures.

However, the use of AI brings questions from both sides– *“is it ethical/unethical?”* Both fresh opportunities and uncertainties are brought about by artificial intelligence. **Propaganda, deepfakes, impersonation**, translating extreme content, and speeding up and expanding online messaging are just a few of the ways that generative AI can be abused. While commercially available drones and other autonomous or remotely operated technology can raise additional security problems, AI-enabled systems may potentially facilitate cyber operations. But just because these capabilities exist doesn't guarantee that every business has them or can make good use of them. Actors differ greatly in terms of financing, infrastructure, equipment access, operational experience, and technical expertise. Therefore, it's critical to differentiate between known technological uses and possible risks in the future.

Another significant development is the convergence of terrorism and cybercrime. To get resources, hide activity, or make operations easier, some actors may try to take use of encrypted platforms, cybercrime-as-a-service, illegal internet markets, or digital financial systems. Governments and foreign partners can also employ digital technologies to enhance investigations, identify dangers, analyze information, and disrupt financing. These advancements raise challenging issues about jurisdiction, attribution, technology corporations' obligations, and striking a balance between fundamental rights and national security. Effective solutions must take into consideration the possibility of technology abuse without viewing online behavior or technical advancement as intrinsically suspicious.

For this committee, the central challenge is to understand how emerging technologies may influence the strategies, capabilities, and relationships of the represented actors. In addition to considering how technology could be used to carry out or facilitate hostile operations, delegates should also consider how reliance on technology creates vulnerabilities and potential reactions from rival actors. Realistic solutions include international intelligence sharing, key infrastructure protection, responsible AI system monitoring, disrupting terrorist financing, and collaboration with pertinent technology companies should be the main topics of discussion. Any suggested course of action should take into account its viability, potential unintended repercussions, and compliance with civilian protection commitments and applicable international law.

Non-State Actors: Profiles, Capabilities and Strategic Interests

The committee brings together a diverse range of non-state actors, armed movements, political organizations, and state-linked forces operating across the Middle East, South Asia, and Africa. The political goals, organizational structures, territorial influence, resources, and connections with national governments of these actors vary greatly. While some function mainly as militant or insurgent groups, others have gained positions in politics or administration. Delegates should refrain from portraying all actors as having the same status under international law since their legal classifications differ between jurisdictions.

Examining how artificial intelligence and new technology affect modern conflicts requires an understanding of these distinctions. Actors may use digital platforms for recruiting and propaganda, leverage AI-generated content to sway public opinion, use unmanned aircraft systems, rely on encrypted communications, or take advantage of digital financial networks, depending on their resources and capabilities. But technological prowess shouldn't be taken for granted without proof. Delegates must evaluate the technological capabilities of the players they are allocated, discern between fact and fiction, and take into account how their political and strategic goals affect their choices.

The following profiles provide a starting point for research. They are not exhaustive assessments of each actor's capabilities, nor do they imply that every organization listed is legally designated as a terrorist organization by the United Nations.

Non-State Actor	Background and areas of research	References and Resources

Hezbollah	A Lebanese political and armed organization with substantial regional influence. Delegates should examine its political role, military structure, regional relationships, communications, and reported use of unmanned systems.	Council on Foreign Relations — search *Hezbollah*; UN Security Council
Hamas	A Palestinian Islamist movement with a political and military structure that has exercised governance in Gaza. Research should examine its organizational structure, propaganda, recruitment, communications, and use of digital platforms.	Council on Foreign Relations — search *Hamas*; UN OCHA
Houthi Movement / Ansar Allah	A Yemeni movement that controls significant territory and has engaged in regional military operations. Delegates should investigate its political objectives, territorial control, reported use of drones and missiles, and information operations.	Council on Foreign Relations — search *Houthis*; UN Yemen
Palestinian Islamic Jihad (PIJ)	A Palestinian militant organization. Research should focus on its organizational structure, regional relationships, recruitment, communications, and role in the Israeli–Palestinian conflict.	Council on Foreign Relations — search *Palestinian Islamic Jihad*; UN Security Council
Popular Mobilization Forces (PMF)	An umbrella structure of armed groups in Iraq, operating within a formal state framework, although individual factions differ in their affiliations and degree of state control. Delegates should examine command structures, state relationships, and differences between constituent factions.	International Crisis Group — search *Iraq Popular Mobilization Forces*; UNAMI

Badr Organization	An influential Iraqi political and armed organization associated with the PMF framework. Research should examine its political influence, relationship with Iraqi institutions, organizational structure, and regional alignments.	International Crisis Group — search *Badr Organization Iraq*; UNAMI
Kata'ib Hezbollah	An Iraqi armed faction with regional connections. Delegates should research its political and military relationships, public statements, and reported activities, distinguishing independently verified information from contested claims.	Council on Foreign Relations — search *Kata'ib Hezbollah*; US Department of State
Harakat al-Nujaba	An Iraqi Shia armed group with regional ties. Relevant research includes its organizational structure, political relationships, regional activities, and information and communications practices.	International Crisis Group — search *Harakat al-Nujaba*; UNAMI
Taliban	The de facto authorities governing Afghanistan since August 2021. Delegates should examine its governance structures, security apparatus, use of digital communications, counterterrorism commitments, and international recognition issues.	UN Assistance Mission in Afghanistan; UN Security Council — Afghanistan
Syrian Democratic Forces (SDF)	A multi-ethnic armed coalition that has played a major role in northeastern Syria, including operations against ISIS. Research should cover its command structure, territorial responsibilities, security operations, digital security, and relationships with external actors.	International Crisis Group — search *Syrian Democratic Forces*; UN Syria
Kurdistan Workers'	A Kurdish militant organization involved in a prolonged conflict with Türkiye.	Council on Foreign Relations — search

Party (PKK)	Delegates should examine its political objectives, regional presence, recruitment, communications, and designation under relevant national and international frameworks.	*PKK*; UN Security Council
National Resistance Front of Afghanistan (NRF)	An armed opposition movement formed after the Taliban's return to power. Research should consider its leadership, opposition activities, resource constraints, communications, and information dissemination.	International Crisis Group — search *Afghanistan National Resistance Front*; UNAMA
Sudan Liberation Movement / Army (SLM/A)	The name refers to a movement with different factions and leaderships, so the precise faction assigned to the delegate must be identified. Research should cover its leadership, position in Sudan's conflicts, territorial presence, alliances, and communications.	International Crisis Group — search *Sudan Liberation Movement*; UN Sudan
Rapid Support Forces (RSF)	A Sudanese paramilitary force involved in the country's ongoing armed conflict. Delegates should investigate its command structure, territorial operations, information campaigns, reported technology use, and relationship with Sudanese state institutions.	UN Independent International Fact-Finding Mission for the Sudan; International Crisis Group
Al-Shabaab	An al-Qaeda-affiliated militant organization operating primarily in Somalia and the wider East African region. Research should examine its insurgency, propaganda, recruitment, financing, and use of communications technology.	UN Security Council — Somalia; Africa Center for Strategic Studies
Jama’at Nusrat al-Islam wal-	An al-Qaeda-affiliated militant coalition active in the Sahel. Delegates should	UN Security Council; Africa

Muslimin (JNIM)	examine its regional networks, recruitment, propaganda, financing, and relationship with local conflicts and governance challenges.	Center for Strategic Studies

Relevance to the Agenda

By including these non-state actors, the committee is able to investigate how modern conflict is shaped by operational contexts, political goals, and technological capabilities. Delegates should think about how the operations of their designated actor may be impacted by artificial intelligence, digital propaganda, cyber threats, unmanned systems, encrypted communications, and developing financial technologies, as well as how other actors or governments might react.

The consequences of technological advancement, disinformation, harm to civilians, and risks to cross-border security should also be taken into account by delegates. Instead than assuming that every player has sophisticated cyber capabilities or powerful AI systems, proposals should be based on the assigned party's documented capabilities and reasonable resources.

Applications of Emerging Technologies by Terrorist Organizations

Terrorist organizations may exploit emerging technologies across several areas, including **propaganda, recruitment, communication, financing, intelligence gathering, and operational planning**. Some organizations have been able to coordinate supporters using online platforms, quickly distribute content, and reach audiences beyond national borders because of the availability of digital tools. However, depending on their resources, technical know-how, geographic reach, outside assistance, and strategic goals, companies use technology in very different ways. The committee should make a distinction between capabilities that are still hypothetical or have scant evidence and proven patterns of technology abuse.

Firstly, Artificial intelligence can be abused to create or translate propaganda, create fake photos and videos, pose as prominent personalities, and customize messages for various audiences. During times of conflict, such applications might exacerbate disinformation and make it more difficult to discern between real and fake content. It is also possible to use digital communication platforms and encrypted messaging services to deliver content to supporters or plan events. However, these technologies have legitimate use, and their existence does not prove terrorist action or intent.

Secondly, Other security issues include digital financial technology, cyber capabilities, and unmanned aerial systems (UAS). While cyber operations may target digital services, public institutions, or key infrastructure, commercially available drones may be modified for surveillance or attacks. Online payment systems and virtual assets can be used to transfer or hide money, but they can also leave records that help with financial investigations. Satellite photography, publicly accessible digital data, and open-source intelligence (OSINT) could assist actors in keeping an eye on events and evaluating their environment. Rather than relying solely on conjecture, the degree to which any given organization employs these technologies must be assessed using reliable, actor-specific data.

Lastly, emerging technologies can also create vulnerabilities for the organizations that use them. Financial transactions may be tracked, online networks disrupted, digital communications watched, and modified content made public. Data analysis, digital forensics, and AI-assisted tools can be used by governments and international partners to support investigations and spot possible threats, but these techniques raise concerns about accuracy, privacy, accountability, and the possibility of misidentification. Examining how technology impacts the capacities and constraints of their designated players, how those capacities impact alliances and conflict dynamics, and what practical steps could lessen harm are the main tasks for delegates. Technical viability, civilian protection, and adherence to relevant international law should all be taken into account in proposed directives.

Threats to International Peace and Security

The exploitation of artificial intelligence and emerging technologies by terrorist organizations can pose significant threats to international peace and security. While cyber operations and attacks against vital infrastructure can interrupt vital services and erode public trust in institutions, digital platforms enable destructive content, propaganda, and disinformation to swiftly traverse national borders. These dangers are not limited to the area where an organization operates; they may have an impact on nearby nations, multinational corporations, humanitarian efforts, and civilian populations all around the world. Therefore, states and pertinent international organizations must work together to combat technology-enabled terrorism.

The potential for new technology to exacerbate already-existing conflicts and **produce new types of instability** is one of the main concerns. During times of political or military crisis, AI-generated false information and deepfakes may be used to escalate tensions, sway public opinion, or erode trust in governments. Widespread disruption can result from cyberattacks targeting financial networks, healthcare institutions, energy systems, and communications infrastructure. In a similar vein, the use of drones and other remotely operated technologies may put civilians, aid workers, and security forces at greater risk. These capabilities can make de-escalation efforts more difficult and raise the risk of unforeseen outcomes when paired with regional rivalries and ongoing armed conflicts.

The different links between armed non-state groups and state authorities further complicate the framework of international security. While some organizations function alone or rely on illegal networks, others may get political, financial, logistical, or technological help from outside sources. These connections can make attribution, responsibility, and diplomatic responses more difficult, especially when the evidence is disputed or insufficient. However, political alignment, technological collaboration, or the use of comparable instruments do not prove that a state oversaw or supervised a specific operation. To prevent unwarranted escalation, responses must be grounded in reliable evidence and relevant international law.

Delegates, therefore, are required to take into account how dangers facilitated by technology impact civilian protection, international stability, and collaboration between governments and non-state actors. Practical steps like enhancing cross-border information sharing, bolstering the resilience of vital infrastructure, stopping terrorist financing, tackling malevolent applications of AI, and creating suitable channels for international cooperation should all be discussed. The repercussions of suggested acts, such as the possibility of reprisals, escalation, misidentification, and limitations on

acceptable civilian uses of technology, should also be taken into account by delegates. The goal is to create practical guidelines that manage security risks, uphold international law, and lessen the likelihood of larger conflicts.

Existing International Legal and Institutional Framework

The Counter-Terrorism Committee (CTC) operates within an established framework of United Nations Security Council resolutions and international policy guidance designed to prevent and combat terrorism. The CTC was created by the **UN Security Council Resolution 1373 (2001)**, which mandates that states increase international cooperation, deny safe havens, and take action against financing terrorism. The work of the CTC and the changing connection between terrorism and information and communications technology (ICT) are discussed in Resolution 2129 (2013). While Resolution 2462 (2019) fortifies international efforts to prevent and suppress the financing of terrorism, including through developing financial technology, Resolution 2396 (2017) focuses on foreign terrorist fighters, border security, and the exploitation of ICT by terrorist organizations. Resolution 2617 (2021) addresses the Counter-Terrorism Committee Executive Directorate's (CTED) role and encourages ongoing efforts to combat emerging terrorist threats, especially those employing technology.

In addition to these resolutions, the CTC has developed policy guidance addressing specific technological challenges. The Delhi Declaration (2022), for example, emphasizes human rights and other interrelated issues, while offering non-binding guidelines on terrorist exploitation of financial technology, ICT, and unmanned aircraft systems (UAS). Likewise, the prevention and combating of terrorist use of unmanned aircraft systems are covered in the Abu Dhabi Guiding Principles (2023). Similarly, the prevention, detection, and disruption of the abuse of new and future financial technology for terrorist purposes are the main goals of the Algeria Guiding Principles (2025). These declarations and guiding principles, in contrast to Security Council resolutions, are not legally binding on their own but rather serve as policy recommendations.

The wider legal framework also includes applicable international human rights law, international humanitarian law where an armed conflict exists, international refugee law where relevant, domestic criminal law, and international counter-terrorism conventions. Counterterrorism actions are kept in line with governments' legal commitments thanks to these legal frameworks. It is important for delegates to understand that not all cyber operations are armed attacks, and not all terrorist uses of new technologies are subject to the same legal regulations. The particular circumstances, the type and effects of the behavior, and the applicable law all influence the applicable legal framework.

Challenges in Countering Technologically Enabled Terrorism

One of the principal challenges in countering technologically enabled terrorism is the accessibility, affordability, and rapid evolution of digital tools. Unlike conventional military equipment, many technologies exploited by terrorist organizations are commercially available and have legitimate civilian uses, making them difficult to regulate without affecting ordinary users. A documented example is the Islamic State's use of commercially available drones in Iraq and Syria from approximately 2016 onwards for surveillance, propaganda, and attacks. The United Nations has highlighted these developments and the difficulty of preventing the misuse of civilian drone technology. This case illustrates how relatively accessible equipment can create security threats without requiring an organization to possess the technological resources of a state.
(https://www.un.org/counterterrorism/sites/default/files/malicious-use-of-ai-uncct-unicri-report-hd.pdf)

Then, finding the people and institutions in charge of internet activity presents a second difficulty. Supporters of terrorism may employ intermediaries, operate on several platforms, hide their identities, or take use of services hosted in other jurisdictions. It may be difficult for investigators to differentiate coordinated terrorist action from unrelated internet behavior, individual sympathizers, or regular criminal activity. A 2024 report by the United Nations Office of Counter-Terrorism and UNICRI, Beneath the Surface, examines how terrorist and violent extremist actors may exploit the dark web and cybercrime-as-a-service, while highlighting the difficulties of attribution and the need for stronger investigative capabilities. Such cases demonstrate why effective responses require cross-border cooperation, digital forensic expertise, and reliable evidence rather than assumptions about who is responsible. (https://www.un.org/counterterrorism/en/beneath-surface-terrorist-and-violent-extremist-use-dark-web-and-cybercrime-service-cyber-attacks)

For governments, researchers, and tech corporations, the increasing use of artificial intelligence presents new challenges. Propaganda produced by AI, altered photos, synthetic audio, and deepfakes can make it more difficult to confirm information, recognize reliable sources, and react swiftly to false narratives. In September 2026, the UN Counter-Terrorism Committee Executive Directorate reported that terrorist propaganda was becoming more decentralised and technologically sophisticated, with AI increasingly used to support multilingual outreach, recruitment, and fundraising. However, investigators must distinguish documented cases of AI misuse from potential scenarios, and automated detection systems can also misclassify legitimate content. Removing material too aggressively may restrict lawful expression, while removing it too slowly may allow harmful content to spread.

(https://www.un.org/securitycouncil/ctc/news/cted%E2%80%99s-latest-trends-report-examines-evolution-terrorist-propaganda)

Lastly, disparities in national laws, technical capabilities, political priorities, and privacy & surveillance make international collaboration challenging. A legitimate request for information may be sent to a platform operating in one nation from another, but jurisdictional and legal differences may cause inquiries to take longer. Additionally, some jurisdictions lack the resources necessary to analyze digital evidence or identify sophisticated cyberthreats, which results in uneven counterterrorism capabilities. Therefore, this committee's task is to create practical guidelines that enhance information exchange, bolster technical capabilities, foster ethical collaboration with technology suppliers, and safeguard vital infrastructure without compromising fundamental rights. In addition to deciding which policies are desired, delegates should think about who would carry them out, how they would be financed, what evidence would prompt action, and how their efficacy would be assessed.

Stakeholders and Their Roles

Governments, international organizations, tech firms, financial institutions, and civil society must work together to prevent terrorists from using developing technologies. In order to fulfill its international counterterrorism commitments, member states play a crucial role by passing and upholding domestic legislation, looking into terrorist activity, exchanging pertinent information, and working together across national boundaries. The Counter-Terrorism Committee (CTC) finds policy gaps, promotes coordinated international action, and keeps an eye on the application of pertinent Security Council resolutions. The Counter-Terrorism Committee Executive Directorate (CTED) supports the CTC by conducting evaluations, offering analysis, and identifying gaps in the country's counterterrorism capabilities, including those pertaining to developing technology.

The United Nations Office of Counter-Terrorism (UNOCT) coordinates UN-wide counter-terrorism efforts and supports Member States through capacity-building programmes and assistance in implementing the UN Global Counter-Terrorism Strategy. Tech firms, on the other hand, are crucial as they create and run digital platforms, AI systems, and communication infrastructure that terrorist groups could utilize. Enhancing platform security, evaluating risks, identifying abuse, and legitimately assisting pertinent authorities while upholding users' rights are some of their duties. By keeping an eye on transactions, adhering to relevant financial regulations, and spotting and reporting questionable financial activity in compliance with the law, financial institutions and virtual asset service providers make a contribution.

Additionally, international and regional organizations facilitate technical assistance to address common security concerns, foster cross-border cooperation, and create standards within their respective mandates. Through independent research, community participation, analysis of new threats, and investigation of the social ramifications of counterterrorism measures, civil society organizations and research institutes make a contribution. Their participation is especially crucial to guaranteeing that security measures are grounded in evidence and do not unduly impede the right to privacy, freedom of speech, or other essential liberties.

Previous International Efforts and Lessons Learned

- **The Delhi Declaration, 2022**

Adopted by the CTC on 29 October 2022 following its special meeting in India, the Delhi Declaration established non-binding policy guidance on countering the use of new and emerging technologies for terrorist purposes.

Its main areas of focus were unmanned aircraft systems, information and communications technologies, and terrorist financing. It also emphasized international cooperation, the involvement of relevant stakeholders and respect for human rights.

- **The Abu Dhabi Guiding Principles, 2023**

These principles focused on terrorist exploitation of unmanned aircraft systems. They provide a policy foundation for discussing risk assessment, national preparedness and cooperation to address drone-related threats.

- **The Algeria Guiding Principles, 2025**

Adopted on 6 January 2025, these non-binding principles address the prevention, detection and disruption of terrorist exploitation of new and emerging financial technologies. They build on the broader approach established by the Delhi Declaration.

- **UN research on AI and terrorism**

The joint UNICRI–UNOCT report Algorithms and Terrorism examines potential malicious uses of AI and offers a foundation for anticipatory policy development. CTED has also continued to convene discussions on terrorist exploitation of generative technologies and digital ecosystems.

Lessons for the Committee

A strong policy often comes with careful considerations, unanimous agreements, and effective solutions. Previous efforts demonstrate that an ideal international policy should:

- **build** on existing Security Council obligations instead of duplicating them unnecessarily;
- **distinguish** binding obligations from voluntary guidance;
- **combine** technology-based responses with legal and institutional reforms;
- **involve** private-sector and civil-society expertise;
- **account** for differences in national capabilities;
- **incorporate** human rights and the rule of law from the beginning.

Key Questions Before the Committee

Delegates should consider the following questions while developing their country's position.

- How can states exchange intelligence without exposing sensitive information and risk jeopardizing their sovereignty?
- Should tech giants such as OpenAI, Anthropic, Meta, Microsoft etc, conduct assessments on advanced AI models of future terrorist misuse?
- How should states address AI Systems that are deployed without safeguards without undermining public trust?
- What responsibilities should online platforms have while detecting terrorist content while avoiding legitimate content?
- Should states adopt minimum cybersecurity standards to avoid the disruption of interconnected networks and protect critical infrastructure?
- How can Member states prevent the acquisition of Fatal Technology without restricting legitimate civilian applications?
- How might emerging technologies affect the objectives and capabilities of the assigned actor?
- What should states do to provide remedies for people who were wrongly identified by an autonomous system used by authorities for the detection of terrorist content?

Possible Areas for Committee Action

Towards the conclusion of debates, the committee should ideally lean into discussing probable solutions and actions. Now it is important to note that the committee proceedings will follow a rather **crisis-action-wise** order. This essentially implies that there will be, in addition to regular formal and informal debates, moments of action and crisis. When this occurs, the committee should ideally stray away from preset topics and focus on the actions of the events. However, you can feel free to also pursue a rational, more policy-oriented mode of debate. Additionally, the following are potential policy directions for delegates to research and negotiate. They are not predetermined outcomes, and their feasibility will depend on the CTC's mandate, existing law and the specific wording of any proposed action.

- **Strengthening implementation of existing resolutions**

The Committee might identify common implementation gaps, promote improved application of pertinent Security Council decisions, and allow the sharing of best practices.

- **International guidelines for AI and emerging technologies**

Further non-binding guidelines for evaluating and preventing terrorist misuse of AI and other dual-use technology could be developed by member states. Risk assessment, human monitoring, accountability, and collaboration with pertinent parties could all be covered by such guidelines.

- **Information-sharing and early-warning mechanisms**

Delegates should look at ways to communicate genuine concerns across jurisdictions, preserve pertinent digital evidence, and exchange information on new terrorist threats.

- **Public-private partnerships**

Governments, IT firms, cybersecurity providers, financial institutions, and research organizations might all benefit from the Committee's encouragement of organized collaboration.

- **Capacity-building and technical assistance**

Investigator training, enhanced digital forensic skills, cybersecurity support, and aid for states lacking the capacity to execute sophisticated counterterrorism measures are all possible proposals.

- **Counter-drone and cybersecurity cooperation**

Common risk-assessment procedures, incident-response coordination, and voluntary technical expertise exchanges regarding terrorist abuse of drones and cyber systems could be investigated by member states.

- **Human rights, transparency and accountability safeguards**

Clear legal authorization for invasive procedures, independent oversight, regular evaluation of automated systems, and channels for contesting incorrect choices are some examples of proposals.

All in all, the problem, the accountable parties, the execution strategy, the necessary resources, and the methodology for evaluating progress should all be identified in a credible resolution. Although not necessary, it should make clear if each suggested action is mandatory, optional, or merely a suggestion.

Questions & Areas a Delegate Should Consider

By now, you will have an understanding of how the agenda ties into various factors. You will also have at your disposal key questions and ideal solutions towards the same. However, if you're unfamiliar with how you should go about your country's research, or if you simply want to further expand on your research, the following questions and areas will prove to be helpful:

Research area	Questions to investigate
National policy	What laws govern terrorism, AI, cybersecurity, digital finance and drones in your country?
International commitments	Which Security Council resolutions and international conventions are relevant to your country?
National capabilities	Does your country have the resources and technical expertise to detect and investigate technologically enabled terrorist activity?
National interests	How might proposed restrictions affect your country's security, economy, technology sector and civil liberties?
International cooperation	With which countries or organizations does your country cooperate on cybersecurity and counter-terrorism?
Proposed solutions	Would your country support binding requirements, voluntary guidelines, technical assistance or a combination of these?
Implementation challenges	How would your proposals be funded, enforced and evaluated?
Accountability	What safeguards would your country support for surveillance, automated decision-making and information sharing?

Furthermore, Delegates should also identify potential allies and areas of disagreement. For example, States may agree on the need to prevent terrorist drone attacks while

disagreeing over export controls, access to encrypted data or the extent of government oversight of private AI companies. The objective is not to assume a country's position based on geography or political alignment, but to establish it through official policy documents, legislation, diplomatic statements and voting records. In the end, however, the power lies in your hands. Use it wisely!

Conclusion: The Central Dilemma

All in all, a Delegate should not overlook the central idea of the agenda, i.e., to ***address the exploitation*** of artificial intelligence and emerging technologies without overlooking the political realities, competing persons and places of interest, and humanitarian consequences of contemporary conflict. Delegates must balance strategic objectives with practical limitations, evaluate claims critically, and develop realistic responses to an evolving situation.

Furthermore, it is also important to note that Terrorist groups' use of new technology and artificial intelligence poses a growing threat to global peace and security. In addition to giving governments new tools to identify threats, look into crimes, and safeguard vital infrastructure, these technologies have the potential to improve the speed, scope, and sophistication of terrorist actions. But the technologies aren't intrinsically terrorist. There are valid uses for AI, drones, encryption, digital money, and sophisticated computers in the fields of healthcare, education, business, science, public safety, and humanitarian aid. Indiscriminately restricting them could have serious negative social and economic effects without successfully stopping malicious use. Thus, three interrelated concerns need to be addressed by the international community:

1. **Security**: Stop terrorist groups from using technology to finance, recruit, launch attacks, and engage in other illegal actions.
2. **Cooperation**: Reduce differences in country counterterrorism capabilities, enhance information sharing, and better carry out current international responsibilities.
3. **Rights and innovation**: Make sure that counterterrorism measures uphold legitimate technical advancement, safeguard fundamental freedoms, and adhere to international law.

In order to prevent counterterrorism measures from causing new harm, delegates should strive to create recommendations that are sufficiently accountable, flexible enough to suit various national conditions, and detailed enough to address identifiable risks. Success will depend not only on identifying threats, but also on making informed decisions, negotiating effectively, and considering the broader consequences of each proposed action.

Further Research and References

1) References

Guide section	Recommended references
1. Introduction to the Agenda	UNOCT — Cybersecurity and New Technologies; UNICRI/UNOCT — Algorithms and Terrorism
2. Mandate and Role of the CTC	About the CTC; What the CTC Does; CTC Security Council Resolutions
3. Evolving Technological Landscape of Terrorism	UNOCT — Cybersecurity and New Technologies; UNICRI — Countering Terrorism Online with Artificial Intelligence
4. Applications of Emerging Technologies	Algorithms and Terrorism; CTC — New and Emerging Technologies; CTC — Delhi Declaration
5. Non-State Actors: Profiles, Capabilities and Strategic Interests	International Crisis Group; Council on Foreign Relations; UN Security Council; UN OCHA
6. Existing International Legal and Institutional Framework	CTC — Security Council Resolutions; Delhi Declaration; CTC Policy Guidance; UN Global Counter-Terrorism Strategy
7. Challenges in Countering Technologically Enabled Terrorism	UNICRI — Algorithms and Terrorism; OHCHR — Human Rights; UNOCT — Cybersecurity and New Technologies
8. Stakeholders and Their Roles	UNOCT; CTED; CTC — Delhi Declaration

9. Previous International Efforts and Lessons Learned	UN Global Counter-Terrorism Strategy; CTC — New and Emerging Technologies; CTC — Security Council Resolutions
10. Key Questions Before the Committee	Delhi Declaration; Algorithms and Terrorism
11. Possible Areas for Committee Action	CTC Policy Guidance; UNOCT — Cybersecurity and New Technologies
12. Questions a Delegate Should Consider	International Crisis Group; Council on Foreign Relations; UN Digital Library
13. Committee Format and Rules of Engagement	Refer to the committee's own Rules of Procedure and instructions issued by the Executive Board.
14. Crisis Scenario and Current Situation	Use the scenario and updates supplied by the Executive Board. For real-world context, consult UN News and International Crisis Group.
15. Directives: Purpose and Function	Refer to the committee's directive template and procedural guidance issued by the Executive Board. These determine submission, approval, voting, and implementation.
16. Actor Objectives, Alliances and Constraints	International Crisis Group; Council on Foreign Relations; UN Security Council
17. Technological Capabilities and Limitations	UNICRI — Algorithms and Terrorism; UNOCT — Cybersecurity and New Technologies
18. Legal, Humanitarian	OHCHR; International Committee of the Red Cross

and Ethical Considerations (ICRC); UN Global Counter-Terrorism Strategy

2) Recurring keywords and terms

During the course of the 3 days of debating, you will come across a certain “lingo” used by delegates. These terms will come up repeatedly in speeches, negotiations, research, and directives. Therefore, Delegates should understand them before the committee begins:

Term	Meaning in the context of this committee
Artificial Intelligence (AI)	Systems that perform tasks such as generating content, recognizing patterns, or analyzing information.
Generative AI	AI that creates new text, images, audio, video, or other content.
Cyberterrorism	A term used for cyber activity intended to advance terrorist objectives; its precise definition varies. Not every cyberattack is terrorism.
Information and Communications Technology (ICT)	Digital systems and networks used to create, store, transmit, or exchange information.
Deepfake	AI-generated or manipulated audio, video, or images that can make a person appear to say or do something they did not.
Disinformation / Misinformation	Disinformation is deliberately misleading information; misinformation is false or inaccurate information, regardless of intent.
Unmanned Aircraft System (UAS)	An unmanned aircraft and the associated equipment used to operate it; commonly includes drones.
Critical Infrastructure	Essential systems such as electricity,

	telecommunications, transport, water, and healthcare.
Terrorist Financing	The provision or collection of funds intended to support terrorist acts or organizations, as defined under applicable law.
Virtual Assets	Digital representations of value that can be transferred or traded electronically, including certain cryptocurrencies.
Encryption	The process of converting information into a protected form to prevent unauthorized access.
Open-Source Intelligence (OSINT)	Information gathered and analyzed from publicly available sources.
Foreign Terrorist Fighter (FTF)	A person who travels to another state to perpetrate, plan, or prepare terrorist acts, or to provide or receive terrorist training, subject to the applicable definition.
Capacity-Building	Strengthening an institution's knowledge, skills, technology, and ability to respond to a problem.
International Humanitarian Law (IHL)	Rules governing conduct during armed conflict; it does not apply to every security incident.
Directive	In this simulation, an action-oriented document proposing a specific decision or course of action, subject to the committee's rules.
De facto authority	An entity exercising effective control or governance in practice, regardless of whether it has formal international recognition.

3) Recommended research links for delegates

These are the most useful starting points for research beyond the individual section references above.

United Nations and official documents

Best for resolutions, mandates, international declarations, and primary-source material.

UN Digital Library · UN Security Council · UNOCT

Conflict analysis and actor research

Useful for understanding armed groups, regional alliances, leadership, territorial influence, and conflict dynamics.

International Crisis Group · Council on Foreign Relations · ACLED conflict data

AI, technology and counter-terrorism

Research on AI misuse, online propaganda, emerging technologies, and responsible counter-terrorism measures.

UNICRI — Algorithms and Terrorism · UNOCT technology programme

International law and humanitarian concerns

Useful for researching civilian protection, armed conflict, human rights, and legal obligations.

International Committee of the Red Cross · OHCHR

Current developments and humanitarian context

Useful for recent developments, civilian impacts, displacement, and humanitarian conditions in conflict zones.

UN News · UN OCHA

Delegates should prioritize official documents, established research institutions, and credible reporting. For claims about a particular actor, they should distinguish confirmed facts from allegations, verify the publication date, and cross-check important claims against more than one reliable source. For the committee's emerging-technology agenda, the UNICRI report Algorithms and Terrorism and the CTC's Delhi Declaration are particularly useful starting points.

Documentation

In this committee, you will be asked to submit **directives** instead of draft resolutions. Directives are formal documents used by delegates to propose and coordinate specific actions in response to developments within the committee. Unlike traditional Model UN draft resolutions, which generally outline broad policies and recommendations, directives focus on actionable decisions, such as establishing temporary alliances, allocating resources, gathering intelligence, conducting negotiations, or responding to an emerging crisis. Their scope and permitted actions depend on the committee's rules of procedure and the powers assigned to delegates by the Executive Board.

Submission

Directives may be submitted individually or collaboratively, depending on the nature of the proposed action and the applicable rules of procedure. Individual directives allow delegates to exercise the authority of their assigned portfolios, while joint directives facilitate cooperation between delegates. Committee-wide directives may also be introduced to coordinate collective action. The Executive Board will review directives for clarity, feasibility, relevance, and consistency with the simulation's rules before determining whether they are approved, rejected, or require modification.

Directives must always remain realistic and precise. Each directive must establish a clear objective, specific actions to take, and the resources and timeframe required for implementation of their directive. Delegates should also consider the immediate ramifications of their actions and anticipate potential complications.

Guidelines for drafting

Each directive must follow a precise format, as is given below.

Title:

Type: [Covert/Overt]

From:

To:

Primary Objective:

Secondary Objective(optional):

Mission Briefing:

Plan of Action:

[Must be very detailed]

Signatories:

Happy Debating!
